

Train to Edinburgh - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

The East Coast Main Line: Racing History

The four-hundred-mile London-to-Edinburgh run you're on is the East Coast Main Line, assembled in the 1840s and 50s by three companies and glamorized for a century by the Flying Scotsman — originally the name of the 10 AM departure from King's Cross, running daily since 1862, later lent to the most famous locomotive on Earth. The line's competitive history is genuinely entertaining: in the Races to the North of 1888 and 1895, East Coast and West Coast companies covertly raced overnight expresses to Scotland, quietly ignoring their own agreed timetables until a derailment scare ended the fun. The speed landmarks all happened on this route: Flying Scotsman's first authenticated hundred miles per hour in 1934, and Mallard's one hundred twenty-six in 1938 — still the world steam record — set on Stoke Bank south of Grantham, which you passed early in the journey. Sights worth timing your coffee for: Durham, roughly halfway, where the train curves on a viaduct giving a magnificent elevated view of the Norman cathedral and castle on their peninsula — right-hand side northbound, and widely rated among the finest railway views in Europe; then the Northumberland coast, where the line runs close to the North Sea past Alnmouth, with Lindisfarne — Holy Island — and Bamburgh Castle visible on clear days in the distance.

Out of King's Cross: The Modern Racers and a Buried Queen

The train you're on continues a very old competition by thoroughly modern means. If this is one of the London North Eastern Railway expresses, it's an Azuma, the Hitachi fleet that swept away the old diesels in 2019. There's a pleasing loop in that. Azuma is a Japanese word meaning east, fitting for the East Coast line, yet the trains themselves are assembled in the north of England, at Hitachi's factory at Newton Aycliffe in County Durham, which sits just off this very route. Japanese engineering, County Durham labour, running the line the Flying Scotsman made famous, at around one hundred and twenty-five miles an hour without a wisp of smoke.

The departure itself is worth replaying. Out of King's Cross the train plunges almost at once into the Gasworks Tunnel, bored beneath the Regent's Canal, then begins the long climb that generations of drivers knew as the first real test of an engine. Glance left in the early minutes and you'll catch Alexandra Palace on its ridge, the vast Victorian hall from which the BBC transmitted the world's first regular high-definition television broadcasts in 1936. And while you're back at King's Cross in memory, spare a thought for its most photographed corner, the ironwork sign for Platform Nine and Three-Quarters, complete with a half-vanished luggage trolley, courtesy of a certain young wizard.

An hour or so out, the spires of Peterborough Cathedral rise from the flat Fenland to the right. It is one of the great Norman churches of Europe, and beneath its floor lies Catherine of Aragon, first queen of Henry the Eighth, buried here in 1536 after he cast her aside. For a quarter of a century it held a second queen as well. Mary, Queen of Scots was interred here after her execution at nearby Fotheringhay in 1587, until her son, by then King James of a united crown, had her moved to a grander tomb at Westminster. You pass the city of two queens at speed, on the fastest, flattest running anywhere on the line. Somewhere in that fast stretch you also slip past Grantham, an unshowy market town with two improbable sons. It is

where the young Isaac Newton went to grammar school, a few miles from the orchard at Woolsthorpe where the apple is supposed to have fallen, and where, two and a half centuries later, Margaret Thatcher was born above her father's grocer's shop. The Fens hide their history well.

Gresley, the A4s, and Why Mallard Still Wins

Mallard's record deserves more than a number, because it was the summit of a specific and rather beautiful engineering moment. By the 1930s the railways were fighting the motor car and the airplane for glamour, and speed was the weapon of choice. The London and North Eastern Railway had a secret one, its chief engineer, Sir Nigel Gresley, and his A4 Pacifics. Gresley was unusually fascinated by aerodynamics for his age. He shaped the A4 with a smooth, wind-cheating profile said to owe something to the wedge nose of a Bugatti railcar, refined in wind-tunnel tests on scale models. The result was that sloping streamlined snout and the deep garter-blue livery, a machine that looked like the future and sliced through the air instead of fighting it.

He gave them evocative names, many of them birds, Mallard and Bittern and Kingfisher and Wild Swan among them. On the third of July, 1938, Mallard, barely four months old, was sent down Stoke Bank south of Grantham, ostensibly on a brake trial, driven by Joseph Duddington, a man known across the railway for his nerve. It touched one hundred and twenty-six miles an hour, snatching the record from a German locomotive that had managed one hundred and twenty-four and a half two years before. The effort overheated one of the big-end bearings, and the crew wisely eased off, but the number was in the book.

Here is the quietly astonishing part. That record has never been broken, and almost certainly never will be. Within twenty years the main-line railways were abandoning steam altogether for diesel and electric, so nobody seriously tried to build a faster steam engine again. Mallard hit a ceiling that turned out to be permanent, the high-water mark of an entire technology, frozen forever in July 1938. Of the thirty-five A4s that Gresley built, six survive, scattered as far as museums in the United States and Canada, and in 2013 all six were gathered nose to nose in York for the record's seventy-fifth anniversary, a reunion of the fastest steam locomotives the world will ever see. Mallard itself survives, immaculate in its blue, at the National Railway Museum in York, which your train passes. It is, in the most literal sense, the fastest that steam has ever gone, or ever will.

Prince-Bishops, the Tyne, and the Angel

The middle of the journey delivers its scenery in a rush. First Durham, roughly halfway, where the line swings onto a viaduct and hands you what many rate the finest railway view in Britain, the Norman cathedral and its castle rising together on a rock within a tight loop of the River Wear, on the right going north. Look quickly, because it is gone in seconds. That cathedral holds the bones of Saint Cuthbert and of the Venerable Bede, and for centuries Durham was ruled not by a mere bishop but by prince-bishops, churchmen granted near-royal powers, their own courts, their own coinage, even their own army, to hold England's wild northern frontier against the Scots. Cathedral and castle together were among Britain's very first UNESCO World Heritage Sites, listed in 1986. Within their palatinate the prince-bishops minted their own money and raised their own armies, sovereigns in miniature, and the King's writ effectively stopped at the county line, a peculiar arrangement that endured in name until the nineteenth century.

Minutes later comes Newcastle, and one of the great urban entrances by rail anywhere in the world. The train crosses the Tyne on the King Edward the Seventh Bridge of 1906, and for a few seconds the whole cluster of Tyne bridges lines up beside you downstream. The green steel arch of the Tyne Bridge, opened in 1928 and built by Dorman Long of Teesside, the same firm that raised the Sydney Harbour Bridge, which rather explains the family resemblance. Robert Stephenson's double-decked High Level Bridge of

1849, road slung below and rail above. And further down, the tilting Gateshead Millennium Bridge, the so-called Blinking Eye.

Then, on the rise near Gateshead, the sculpture appears, Antony Gormley's Angel of the North, unveiled in 1998, twenty metres tall with a wingspan of fifty-four metres, cast in weathering steel so it wears a permanent russet skin. Modelled on the artist's own body and planted where a colliery once stood, it is seen by some thirty-three million people a year, most of them, like you, in passing. Gormley gave the wings a slight forward tilt, he said, to make an embrace rather than a threat. Consider yourself embraced, and note the theme of this whole region, which built the locomotives, forged the bridges, and now builds the very trains that carry you through it.

Berwick, the Border, and Arriving in Edinburgh

Berwick-upon-Tweed, the last English town, compresses the whole Anglo-Scottish story: it changed hands between the kingdoms around thirteen times before 1482, was for centuries so anomalous that it was named separately in royal proclamations — spawning the enduring myth that Berwick remained technically at war with Russia after the Crimean War — and its Elizabethan ramparts, built against a Scottish invasion that never came, were the most expensive undertaking of Elizabeth the First's reign. Your train crosses the Tweed on Robert Stephenson's Royal Border Bridge, twenty-eight arches completed in 1850, with the actual border a couple of miles further north at Marshall Meadows — marked only by signs and, on the adjacent A1, a piper on good days. The final approach to Edinburgh runs along the East Lothian coast, with the Firth of Forth opening on the right; in the distance you may catch the Bass Rock, a volcanic plug that hosts the world's largest colony of northern gannets and visibly whitens with birds in summer. Waverley station itself is a statement: the only station in Britain named after novels — Walter Scott's Waverley series — sunk in the valley between the medieval Old Town and the Georgian New Town, with the castle looming overhead as you exit. The geography lesson is immediate: everything in central Edinburgh is arranged around that extinct volcano, and tomorrow you'll walk its spine.

Lindisfarne and the Northumberland Coast

Before the border, the line runs close to a coast thick with history, so keep half an eye seaward. Watch east for Holy Island, Lindisfarne, a tidal island severed from the mainland twice a day when the sea floods its causeway. In the seventh century it was the cradle of Northumbrian Christianity, home to Saint Cuthbert and the workshop where the Lindisfarne Gospels were made, that miracle of illuminated manuscript now kept in the British Library. And it was here, in the year 793, that Viking raiders fell on the monastery in an attack so shocking to Christian Europe that many historians date the start of the Viking Age to that single day. Longships on this grey water, and the medieval world tilted on its axis.

The same coast is studded with fortresses, thanks to eight centuries of Anglo-Scottish violence that made every headland worth defending. The showpiece is Bamburgh Castle, an immense pile on a crag of black basalt above the dunes, seat of the Anglo-Saxon kings of Bernicia and in effect an early capital of the north. Inland stands Alnwick Castle, still the seat of the Dukes of Northumberland and familiar to any child as the Hogwarts of the early Harry Potter films. And on a lonely promontory rise the broken towers of Dunstanburgh, reachable only on foot and a favourite subject of the painter Turner. This is Whin Sill country, a great intrusion of hard volcanic rock that surfaces as cliffs and crags right along the shore, and the medieval builders exploited every outcrop of it.

Look to the water, too. Offshore lie the Farne Islands, seabird cities in summer and the place where Cuthbert lived out his last years as a hermit among the puffins and the grey seals. Those same rocks staged one of the great Victorian dramas. On a wild September night in 1838 a paddle-steamer broke apart on them, and a lighthouse keeper's daughter named Grace Darling rowed out through the storm with her father to haul the survivors from the sea, an exploit that made her the most famous woman in Britain almost overnight. She died young and lies in the churchyard at Bamburgh, her memorial deliberately raised high so that passing sailors could see it from the water. All told, it is one of the loveliest stretches of the entire east coast of Britain, and you are getting it for the price of a train ticket, gliding past at a mile a minute while everyone else has to walk.

The Border and the Debatable Land

The frontier you're crossing is one of the oldest and most fought-over in Europe, though today it slips by almost unmarked. The official line lies a couple of miles north of Berwick, near Marshall Meadows, and if you're watching the parallel road you may glimpse a Saltire and a Welcome to Scotland sign. The railway makes no fuss whatsoever. For three hundred years, though, this was among the most lawless corners of the continent, the country of the Border Reivers, raiding families on both sides of the line who spent the late Middle Ages stealing one another's cattle, burning one another's farms, and running protection rackets across the frontier. They were so accomplished at it that they left a word in the English language, blackmail, the illegal payment you handed over for the favour of being left in peace. The reiving families are scattered around the world now by the surnames they left behind, Armstrong and Elliot and Nixon and Kerr among them, and here is a fact worth carrying off the train: the first human being to set foot on the moon, Neil Armstrong, sprang from exactly this borderland stock. In 1974 he came in person to the little town of Langholm, just over the hills, to be made a freeman of the reivers' country, the raider's descendant returned from space.

Away to the west lay the Debatable Land, a strip that for centuries belonged officially to neither kingdom, because neither could govern it, a genuine no-man's-land where the ordinary rules simply lapsed. All of that ferocity ended in earnest only after 1603, when the crowns of England and Scotland were united under one king, James, and the border lost its purpose almost overnight.

Across the line the character of the run changes. The railway clings to the East Lothian coast, past the nuclear station at Torness and the fishing town of Dunbar, birthplace in 1838 of John Muir, the naturalist who did more than any other single person to create America's national parks, Yosemite chief among them. A Scot, in other words, who taught the New World to love its own wilderness, which is worth a quiet moment as an American family rolls past his front door. Then the outskirts of Edinburgh begin to gather, the land lifts, and the city's great volcanic set-pieces heave into view ahead of you.

Arthur's Seat, the Nor Loch, and Waverley

Understand Edinburgh's geology and you understand the entire city, because it is built on the wreckage of volcanoes and ice. The dramatic green mass rising to the east as you arrive is Arthur's Seat, the deeply eroded core of a volcano that last stirred more than three hundred million years ago. Castle Rock, the sheer black crag that carries Edinburgh Castle, is another ancient volcanic plug. During the ice ages, glaciers grinding from west to east slammed into that hard plug and were forced to part around it, scouring away the softer rock behind and leaving a long tapering ramp of debris in its lee. Geologists call the shape a crag and tail, and the medieval city simply obeyed it, the castle on the crag and the Royal Mile running down the tail. Tomorrow you will walk the anatomy of a glacier.

The station you arrive at occupies the strangest site of all. Waverley sits in the deep valley between the medieval Old Town and the Georgian New Town, but that valley was, until the eighteenth century, a body of water, the Nor Loch, a foul, sewage-fed lake that doubled as the town's rubbish dump and, conveniently, the place to drown accused witches. The Georgians drained it, and into the drained bed went the gardens, Princes Street, and eventually this vast station, the only one in the world named after a novel, Walter Scott's Waverley. Look up as you step onto the platform and you'll see Scott's own monument, a soaring Gothic rocket of soot-blackened stone, said to be the largest memorial to a writer anywhere on Earth, some two hundred feet of blackened Gothic pinnacle with sixty-four of Scott's own characters carved climbing its buttresses and a white marble Scott, with his deerhound at his knee, seated beneath.

And above it all, the castle on its rock, the reason a city grew here in the first place. You have travelled some four hundred miles up the spine of Britain, from the flatlands of the Fens to the bones of a volcano, in barely four and a half hours. Step down onto the platform, breathe the sharper northern air, and begin.